

Creating a Basic WordPress Custom Theme from Scratch

Two Academic Hours – Beginner Friendly Guide

Introduction

This lesson introduces students to creating a basic WordPress theme from scratch. The focus is on understanding theme structure, required files, and how WordPress, PHP, HTML, and CSS work together.

Lesson Structure (2 Academic Hours)

- Academic Hour 1: Theme structure, required files, and basic layout
- Academic Hour 2: Template tags, the WordPress Loop, and basic customization

1. Theme Folder Structure

Custom themes are created inside the wp-content/themes directory. Create a new folder for your theme, for example: **my-first-theme**.

```
my-first-theme/  
■■■ style.css  
■■■ index.php  
■■■ header.php  
■■■ footer.php  
■■■ functions.php
```

2. style.css – Theme Information & Styles

The style.css file is required. It contains theme metadata and CSS styles.

```
/*  
Theme Name: My First Theme  
Author: Student Name  
Description: A simple custom WordPress theme.  
Version: 1.0  
*/  
  
body {  
font-family: Arial, sans-serif;  
margin: 0;  
padding: 0;
```

```
}
```

3. index.php – Main Template

index.php is the fallback template used to display content if no other template is found.

```
<?php get_header(); ?>

<main>
  <h1>Blog</h1>

  <?php if (have_posts()) : while (have_posts()) : the_post(); ?>
    <h2><?php the_title(); ?></h2>
    <?php the_content(); ?>
  <?php endwhile; endif; ?>
</main>

<?php get_footer(); ?>
```

4. header.php – Header Layout

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<head>
  <?php wp_head(); ?>
</head>
<body>
<header>
  <h1><?php bloginfo('name'); ?></h1>
</header>
```

5. footer.php – Footer Layout

```
<footer>
  <p>© 2026 My First Theme</p>
</footer>
<?php wp_footer(); ?>
</body>
</html>
```

6. functions.php – Theme Functions

```
<?php
function mytheme_assets() {
  wp_enqueue_style('main-style', get_stylesheet_uri());
}
add_action('wp_enqueue_scripts', 'mytheme_assets');
```

Learning Outcomes

After this lesson, students should understand:

- Theme folder structure
- Required theme files
- Basic WordPress template flow
- How PHP outputs content
- How to activate and customize a theme

Practice Task

1. Create a new theme folder
2. Add required files
3. Customize styles and text
4. Activate the theme in WordPress
5. Modify header and footer content